Do Policy Professionals See the World as It Is - or as They Are? Perceptions of Public Preferences over Redistributive Policy Designs

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Abstract

How accurately do policy professionals perceive public preferences for redistribution? We study this question in the context of energy subsidy reform, a setting in which a regressive status quo can be replaced by cash transfers targeted to poor households or provided universally. We survey World Bank staff, eliciting both their own preferences and their predictions of public support for different transfers across 12 countries, and we compare these predictions to actual public preferences measured in large, standardized public opinion surveys. Support for targeted transfers exceeds support for universal transfers by roughly 45 percentage points among policy professionals, compared with roughly 11 percentage points among citizens. Professionals partly recognize this divergence, predicting a smaller targeting-universality gap among the public

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than in their own preferences, but they still underestimate public support for replacing regressive subsidies. Support among policy professionals for targeted as opposed to universal transfers is predicted by demographic characteristics. While public support for universal transfers is much higher than support for these transfers among policy professionals, those policy professionals who personally support universal transfers predict higher levels of public support for it. This pattern is consistent with projection bias, though it may also reflect other mechanisms.

Keywords: redistributive policy, public preferences, perceptions, projection bias, policy professionals

JEL Codes: D63, D83, D91, H53, I38

1 Introduction

Support for redistributive policies depends not only on objective inequality, but also on how inequality, fairness, and policy instruments are perceived (Alesina and Angeletos, 2005; Norton and Ariely, 2011; Stantcheva, 2024). Citizens often misperceive the level and structure of inequality (Norton and Ariely, 2011; Cruces et al., 2013; Gimpelson and Treisman, 2018), differ in how they interpret the causes and fairness of unequal outcomes (Fong, 2001; Alesina and Angeletos, 2005), and form preferences over redistributive policies partly through beliefs, reference points, social identity, and lived experience (Alesina and Giuliano, 2011; Costa-Font and Cowell, 2015; Roth and Wohlfart, 2018; Hvidberg et al., 2023). While this literature documents how citizens perceive inequality and form preferences over redistribution, much less is known about whether policy professionals accurately perceive citizens' preferences over redistributive policy designs. Yet redistributive policies are not directly designed by citizens: it is policy professionals who are charged with policy design and whose own preferences and beliefs about public preferences may influence which policy instruments are proposed, prioritized, or treated as politically feasible.

We study whether policy professionals' own preferences over redistributive policy designs are associated with how they perceive public preferences. Energy subsidy reform provides a useful setting in which to study questions around preferences for redistributive interventions because it enables a concrete choice among alternative redistributive policy options. Energy subsidies are fiscally large and typically regressive, since higher-income households consume more subsidized energy. Across the countries we study, for every \$1 of energy subsidies received by the poorest 20%, the richest 20% receive approximately \$11 (Hoy et al., 2026). Reform therefore raises a clear distributional question: public resources currently used to lower energy prices could instead be reallocated with households compensated through cash transfers targeted to poor households or provided universally. We use this setting to compare professionals' own support for compensatory targeted and universal cash transfers with their perceptions of public support for those same policy designs.

We elicit these preferences and perceptions in a survey of World Bank staff. Respondents report their own support for replacing energy subsidies with either targeted cash transfers to poor households or universal cash transfers to all households. They also predict public support for the same alternatives in 12 countries. We compare these predictions to country-level public-opinion benchmarks from Hoy et al. (2026).

This design allows us to address three questions: What are policy professionals' own preferences for redistributive policy? How accurately do they predict public preferences over these designs? And are prediction errors associated with professionals' own preferences and contextual familiarity?

Our findings show that policy professionals' own preferences for targeted transfers are higher than citizen preferences in the 12 countries we study. Approximately 81% of professionals support replacing energy subsidies with targeted transfers, compared with 69% of the public, but only 36% of professionals support replacing subsidies with universal transfers, compared with 59% of the public. This results in a targeted-versus-universal support gap of 45 percentage points among professionals, compared with roughly 11 percentage points among citizens. In other words, professionals distinguish much more sharply between targeted and universal programs.

When predicting public preferences, professionals anticipate that the public considers targeted and universal transfers more similarly than they do. However, they under-predict public support for both targeted and universal cash transfers. With regards to universal transfers, where professional and public preferences diverge most, professionals' own support for these transfers predicts higher perceived public support for them. This is consistent with projection bias or a false-consensus effect. We find no analogous relationship for targeted transfers, where professional support is high and variation in own preferences is more limited. We also find suggestive evidence that regional familiarity is associated with lower prediction error for support for universal transfers, though this result depends on the specific measure of familiarity used.

The paper contributes to the literature on perceptions of inequality and preferences for redistribution by shifting attention from citizens to the professionals involved in designing redistributive policy. Existing work shows that redistributive preferences are shaped by perceived inequality, beliefs about fairness and deservingness, social position, and lived experience (Fong, 2001; Alesina and Angeletos, 2005; Norton and Ariely, 2011; Roth and Wohlfart, 2018; Hvidberg et al., 2023; Stantcheva, 2024). We study whether related preference-perception links appear among a consequential but rarely observed population: policy professionals whose judgments may shape which policies with redistributive impacts are implemented.

The paper also contributes to work on second-order beliefs, projection, and elite misperceptions of public opinion. In economics, projection bias is often modeled as over-extrapolating from one's current preferences when predicting future utility (Loewenstein et al., 2003). Closely related work shows that individuals' own types, values, or preferences can shape beliefs about others' views (Ross et al., 1977; Butler et al., 2015; Roth and Voskort, 2014). Political elites also can systematically misperceive constituent opinion (Broockman and Skovron, 2018). Our setting allows us to distinguish three objects that are often conflated: professionals' own policy preferences, their beliefs about public preferences, and measured public support. In doing so, we also contribute to work on policy-professional judgment, which shows that policy professionals can exhibit behavioral biases in decision-making (Banuri et al., 2019) and that policymakers' prior beliefs and updating behavior can differ from those of researchers and other practitioners (Vivalt and Coville, 2023).

Finally, the paper speaks to redistributive policy design in settings where public acceptance is central to implementation. The findings highlight the value of direct evidence on public preferences, not as a substitute for technical judgment, but as a way to clarify where professional beliefs reflect public acceptability and where they may partly reflect professionals' own priors.

2 Energy Subsidies in Low- and Middle-Income Countries

Energy subsidies provide a useful setting for studying preferences over redistributive policy design because they combine large fiscal costs with clear distributional implications. This paper draws on data from a broad set of countries: Angola, Argentina, Bangladesh, Bolivia, Ecuador, Egypt, Ghana, Indonesia, Kazakhstan, Nigeria, Pakistan, and Vietnam. These countries span Asia, Africa, the Middle East, and Latin America, and collectively they accounted for almost US$200 billion in explicit energy subsidies and more than US$550 billion in implicit energy subsidies in 2022. This is equivalent to 4% of country GDP on average and represents a quarter of middle-income country subsidies globally (Hoy et al., 2026). While there is some variation across countries (Appendix Table B1), energy subsidies are regressive in each country considered, and on average the richest quintile benefit eleven times more from energy subsidies than the poorest quintile (Hoy et al., 2026).

In recent years, there has been a push towards reducing universal energy subsidies, particularly in low- and middle-income countries. Across the World Bank, IMF and OECD, energy subsidies are increasingly characterized as fiscally costly, weakly targeted, and distortionary (World Bank, 2023a; IMF, 2025; OECD, 2025). Reform efforts have therefore often emphasized compensating households through cash transfers or existing social protection systems, and cash transfers have in fact been substituted for energy subsidies in several countries: a recent review identified 24 recent energy subsidy reforms across 18 countries involving some form of cash transfer or social assistance as compensation (World Bank, 2023a).

This setting creates a policy-relevant redistributive choice. Maintaining energy subsidies preserves a generally regressive status quo, while replacing subsidies with targeted or universal cash transfers changes both who benefits and how compensation is delivered. The choice between targeted and universal transfers reflects a central tradeoff in social protection design: targeting concentrates resources on poorer households, while universal programs may avoid some informational, administrative, political, and exclusion costs associated with targeting (Hanna and Olken, 2018).

The targeted-universal contrast is distributionally meaningful. Targeted transfers direct compensation to poorer households and therefore align with a need-based or prioritarian rationale, while universal transfers give weight to equal treatment and broad inclusion. Both alternatives are less regressive than maintaining energy subsidies, though targeted transfers would generally be more progressive than universal transfers. Preferences over these alternatives may also reflect beliefs about fiscal efficiency, administrative feasibility, leakage, credibility, or political acceptability. We therefore interpret responses as preferences over redistributive policy designs and as perceptions of public support for those designs, rather than as pure measures of redistribution or inequality aversion.

3 Data and Methods

Our empirical design leverages three types of data: policy professionals' own support for alternative programs, their predictions of public support for those same programs, and country-level public support measured in parallel public opinion surveys. The first two were gathered in a survey of World Bank staff, while the last draws on Hoy et al. (2026). The next subsections describe each in turn.

3.1 Survey of World Bank Staff

World Bank staff were surveyed regarding their own preferences and their beliefs about the preferences of others. We collected data through an in-person survey booth set up at the World Bank headquarters in Washington, DC, over three days in August 2024. Staff passing through common areas were invited to participate and received a small token of appreciation upon completion. The survey was open to all staff regardless of sector or regional assignment, and participants spanned a broad range of the Bank's operational and analytical teams; those in IT or administrative support roles could take the survey but are excluded from all analyses per our pre-analysis plan. Respondents were assigned two study countries and were asked to predict public support for both targeted and universal transfers in each assigned country.[1] Table 1 summarizes the characteristics of respondents. The sample is highly educated, with 89% holding a graduate degree, and predominantly operations-focused, with 84% identifying as operations staff - consistent with the profile of World Bank professional staff engaged in program design. Respondents originate from a geographically diverse set of countries, spanning Africa (10%), East Asia and Pacific (16%), Europe and Central Asia (22%), Latin America and the Caribbean (24%), South Asia (6%), the Middle East and North Africa (4%), and North America (18%). In terms of current work assignments, the sample similarly spans all major World Bank regions, with the largest shares working in Africa (26%) and Latin America and the Caribbean (22%).

We use "policy professionals" to refer to the World Bank professional staff in our sample. The sample should not be interpreted as representative of all World Bank staff, country-office staff, government officials, or policy professionals globally. Its value is that it provides direct evidence from a rarely surveyed group of professionals working in an institution centrally involved in redistributive policy advice. The booth-based recruitment strategy made participation available to a broad cross-section of headquarters staff, though we cannot rule out selection into participation.[2] Although the survey took place at World Bank headquarters, participants came from a diverse range of countries and worked across multiple regions. This diversity is useful for examining heterogeneity by background and contextual familiarity.

The survey consisted of two main modules. In the first module, respondents made predictions about public preferences in specific countries. Each respondent was assigned up to

[1] At the time of survey implementation, we expected public-opinion data to be available for two additional countries, but those external surveys ultimately were not fielded. In addition, not all respondents completed the prediction module for both assigned countries. The final prediction sample therefore contains 288 complete respondent-country pairs based on the 12 countries for which public-opinion benchmarks were available.

[2] Participants would not have known the survey was about redistributive policy designs until they began the survey. The only incentives offered were chocolates or gift cards to a coffee shop.

Table 1: Summary Statistics by Cash Transfer Policy Preferences

	N	Full Sample	**Universal Transfers**		**Targeted Transfers**	
			Support	Oppose	Support	Oppose
Own Support for Universal Transfers	162	0.36 (0.48)	1.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.00)	0.33 (0.47)	0.52 (0.51)
Own Support for Targeted Transfers	162	0.81 (0.39)	0.73 (0.45)	0.85 (0.35)	1.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.00)
Has Graduate Degree	159	0.89 (0.31)	0.81 (0.39)	0.94 (0.24)	0.91 (0.29)	0.83 (0.38)
Childhood Family Income Bucket	153	5.86 (1.91)	5.73 (2.06)	5.93 (1.83)	5.99 (1.92)	5.19 (1.77)
Is Operations Staff	162	0.84 (0.37)	0.86 (0.35)	0.83 (0.38)	0.82 (0.38)	0.90 (0.30)
Country Origin: Log GDP per Capita	156	9.60 (1.41)	9.91 (1.50)	9.43 (1.33)	9.51 (1.37)	9.98 (1.50)
Origin: Africa	157	0.10 (0.30)	0.10 (0.31)	0.10 (0.30)	0.09 (0.29)	0.13 (0.35)
Origin: East Asia & Pacific	157	0.16 (0.37)	0.14 (0.35)	0.17 (0.38)	0.17 (0.37)	0.13 (0.35)
Origin: Europe & Central Asia	157	0.22 (0.41)	0.19 (0.40)	0.23 (0.42)	0.20 (0.41)	0.27 (0.45)
Origin: Latin America & Caribbean	157	0.24 (0.43)	0.22 (0.42)	0.25 (0.44)	0.28 (0.45)	0.10 (0.31)
Origin: Middle East & North Africa	157	0.04 (0.19)	0.03 (0.18)	0.04 (0.20)	0.05 (0.21)	0.00 (0.00)
Origin: South Asia	157	0.06 (0.23)	0.02 (0.13)	0.08 (0.27)	0.06 (0.24)	0.03 (0.18)
Origin: US & Canada	157	0.18 (0.38)	0.28 (0.45)	0.12 (0.33)	0.14 (0.35)	0.33 (0.48)
Works in Africa	162	0.26 (0.44)	0.22 (0.42)	0.28 (0.45)	0.28 (0.45)	0.16 (0.37)
Works in East Asia & Pacific	162	0.04 (0.20)	0.02 (0.13)	0.06 (0.24)	0.05 (0.21)	0.03 (0.18)
Works in Europe & Central Asia	162	0.03 (0.17)	0.03 (0.18)	0.03 (0.17)	0.03 (0.17)	0.03 (0.18)
Works in Latin America & Caribbean	162	0.22 (0.42)	0.20 (0.41)	0.23 (0.42)	0.24 (0.43)	0.16 (0.37)
Works in Middle East & North Africa	162	0.07 (0.25)	0.08 (0.28)	0.06 (0.24)	0.06 (0.24)	0.10 (0.30)
Works in South Asia	162	0.02 (0.14)	0.02 (0.13)	0.02 (0.14)	0.02 (0.15)	0.00 (0.00)
Works in Other/No Assigned Region	162	0.36 (0.48)	0.42 (0.50)	0.32 (0.47)	0.32 (0.47)	0.52 (0.51)

Note: Table is restricted to the 162 respondents with nonmissing cash-transfer own-support outcomes. Values show mean (standard deviation). N is the number of nonmissing observations for each row variable.

two target countries. When possible, one assignment was drawn from a country or region with which the respondent reported familiarity; the other was randomly assigned from the remaining study countries. For each assigned country, respondents predicted the share of citizens who would support each of two compensation designs in the context of energy subsidy reform: replacing energy subsidies with cash transfers targeted to poor households, or replacing energy subsidies with universal cash transfers to all citizens. In both cases, the replacement of energy subsidies was framed as resulting in a 10 percent increase in electricity and fuel prices. In the second module, respondents answered questions about their own support for the two compensation designs in the context of energy subsidy reform. Appendix Figures C2-C4 provide questions from the survey instrument.

3.2 Public Preference Data

We compare World Bank staff predictions to public preferences measured in Hoy et al. (2026), which provides country-level public-opinion data on attitudes toward reducing fossil fuel subsidies in the same 12 countries used in our prediction task. The study surveyed approximately 37,000 respondents across 12 middle-income countries: Angola, Argentina, Bangladesh, Bolivia, Ecuador, Egypt, Ghana, Indonesia, Kazakhstan, Nigeria, Pakistan, and Vietnam.

In each country, approximately 3,000 respondents were surveyed through an online survey, yielding a large cross-country sample of public attitudes toward subsidy reform (Hoy et al., 2026). The sample is designed to be broadly representative of the internet-using population in each country, with survey weights used to match the general population on age, sex, location, income, and education.[3] We therefore interpret the public data as a high-quality, standardized measure of public preferences among the survey population, while recognizing the limitations associated with online survey coverage in middle-income settings.

[3]As noted in Hoy et al. (2026), the online survey modality requires caution when generalizing to populations without internet access, particularly the poorest households and disadvantaged respondents who may be underrepresented.

Public support for energy subsidy reform is measured under a common, policy-relevant framework across all 12 countries. In each country, respondents were asked whether they would prefer that the government maintain electricity and fuel subsidies at current levels or reduce the subsidies and use the resources previously spent on subsidies to implement alternative cash transfer programs. The question stated that reducing subsidies would increase electricity and fuel prices by 10%. Respondents then reported whether they supported reducing subsidies and using the funds for, among other options, cash transfers to poor households or cash transfers to all households.

These data provide the benchmark for our prediction exercise and comparison between policy professional and citizen preferences. In the staff survey, respondents were asked to predict, for assigned countries, the share of public-survey respondents who strongly or somewhat supported reducing subsidies and using the funds for each cash transfer program.[4] The prediction question directly referenced the country-specific public-survey question, including the 10 percent price-increase framing. This allows us to compare staff predictions to country-specific public-support benchmarks. By contrast, staff own-support questions were elicited generally rather than with respect to a specific country. We therefore treat own support as a respondent-level measure of preferences over the two redistributive policy designs, and we interpret comparisons between staff own support and public support as aggregate professional-public contrasts rather than country-specific preference comparisons.

3.3 Outcomes

Our analysis focuses on three main outcomes:

1. **Own support**: World Bank staff members' personal support for replacing energy subsidies with (a) cash transfers targeted to poor households and (b) universal cash

[4] A survey question asked whether participants had previously heard anything about Hoy et al. (2026). 29.4% of those who made at least one prediction claimed to have heard something about this work. Given the literature would tend to suggest over-claiming of familiarity, the true share is likely lower (Atir et al., 2015). As pre-specified, respondents who reported prior familiarity with the benchmark results are excluded from robustness checks.

transfers.

2. **Predicted support**: Staff predictions about the percentage of the public-survey respondents in each assigned country who strongly or somewhat supported reducing energy subsidies and using the funds for each transfer type.

3. **Absolute prediction error**: The absolute difference between predicted public support and actual public support: $\text{AbsError}_{ijc} = |\text{Predicted}_{ijc} - \text{Actual}_{jc}|$. This measure captures forecast inaccuracy regardless of direction.

We also collect data on participant characteristics including education, childhood family income, country of origin, and self-reported familiarity with specific regions. Country of origin allows us to link respondents to country-level characteristics, such as log GDP per capita, that may be associated with support for redistributive policy designs.

3.4 Empirical Strategy

We organize the empirical analysis around three questions. First, how do policy professionals' own support for targeted and universal cash transfers differ, and which respondent characteristics are associated with these differences? Second, are professionals' own views associated with their beliefs about public support for these same policy designs? Third, how accurate are these beliefs relative to country-specific public support benchmarks?

First, examining professionals' own preferences, we estimate separate linear regressions for participants' support for universal and targeted transfers:

$$S_{ij} = \alpha_j + X_i'\beta_j + \epsilon_{ij}, \tag{1}$$

where S_{ij} is participant i's own support for policy $j \in \{\text{universal}, \text{targeted}\}$, and X_i represent participant covariates.[5] We then estimate the within-respondent difference:

$$S_{i,\text{universal}} - S_{i,\text{targeted}} = \alpha + X_i'\beta_\Delta + \epsilon_i. \tag{2}$$

This specification asks which characteristics predict relative support for universal rather than targeted transfers. It is equivalent to a respondent fixed-effects specification in which respondent characteristics are interacted with an indicator for the universal policy. Importantly, this specification controls for preferences the respondent might have towards energy subsidies and focuses on the comparison between universal and targeted transfers.

Second, we examine whether professionals' own support is associated with their beliefs about public support. For each policy design, we estimate:

$$P_{ijc} = \alpha_j + \theta_{1j} S_{i,\text{universal}} + \theta_{2j} S_{i,\text{targeted}} + X_{ic}'\gamma_j + \delta_c + \epsilon_{ijc}, \tag{3}$$

where P_{ijc} is respondent i's prediction of public support for policy j in country c, and δ_c are target-country fixed effects. X_{ic} are again controls and here include an indicator for familiarity with the target region. The coefficients on own support capture whether respondents who personally support a policy design also predict higher public support for that design, conditional on target-country fixed effects and observed respondent characteristics.

We also estimate a within respondent-country specification:

$$P_{i,\text{universal},c} - P_{i,\text{targeted},c} = \alpha + \theta_1 S_{i,\text{universal}} + \theta_2 S_{i,\text{targeted}} + \delta_c + \epsilon_{ic}. \tag{4}$$

This compares the same respondent's predictions for the same country across universal and targeted cash transfers. It therefore differences out respondent-country factors common to

[5] In principle, a long list of potential covariates could be included in this regression, as respondents' country of origin was collected and could be merged to other data sources such as the World Development Indicators. We consider only those covariates that were pre-specified, with the exception that log GDP per capita was added so as to make it easier to interpret a pre-specified covariate capturing childhood relative household income. We describe deviations from the pre-analysis plan in Appendix A.

both predictions, including the respondent's general optimism or pessimism about public support for cash transfers versus energy subsidies and any features of the forecasting task common to both policy designs. The target-country fixed effects absorb country-specific differences in the actual universal-targeted public-support gap. Because actual public support is fixed within country-policy cells, the policy-specific predicted-support specifications in equation (3) are equivalent, for the coefficients on respondents' own support, to specifications using signed prediction error, $P_{ijc} - Q_{jc}$, as the dependent variable. Similarly, equation (4) is equivalent for these coefficients to a signed-error-gap specification comparing universal and targeted transfers within the same respondent-country pair.

Finally, we compare predictions to the country-specific public-support benchmarks. We use absolute prediction error to assess forecast accuracy.

$$A_{ijc} = \alpha_j + \theta_{1j} S_{i,\text{universal}} + \theta_{2j} S_{i,\text{targeted}} + X'_{ic}\gamma_j + \delta_c + \epsilon_{ijc}, \tag{5}$$

where $A_{ijc} = |P_{ijc} - Q_{jc}|$ is the absolute prediction error, and Q_{jc} is actual public support for policy design j in country c. Negative coefficients indicate more accurate forecasts. Since respondents make multiple forecasts, standard errors in the prediction and prediction-error regressions are clustered by respondent. For the own-support regressions, which use one observation per respondent-policy outcome, we report robust standard errors.

4 Results

4.1 Comparing Professional and Public Preferences for Redistributive Programs

Figure 1 compares three quantities: World Bank staff members' own support for the two compensation designs, their predictions of public support, and actual public support from the public-opinion benchmarks. The comparison is aggregate rather than country-specific:

staff own support is elicited generally, while public support is averaged over the country-policy benchmarks corresponding to the prediction sample. We see that policy professionals distinguish much more sharply between targeted and universal compensation than the public does. Approximately 81% of professionals support replacing energy subsidies with cash transfers targeted to poor households, compared with 69% of the public. By contrast, only 36% of professionals support replacing subsidies with universal cash transfers, compared with 59% of the public.

In other words, the key difference between policy professionals and the public is their relative support for targeted versus universal compensatory transfers. Policy professional support is concentrated on the targeted-transfer design. The targeting-universality gap is approximately 45 percentage points among professionals, compared with about 11 percentage points among the public.

Figure 1 also shows that professionals correctly anticipate that the public distinguishes less sharply between targeted and universal transfers than they do themselves. However, they under-predict public support for cash transfers overall.

In contrast to Figure 1, which shows the pooled comparison, Figure 2 compares mean predicted and actual public support by country. Points above the 45-degree line indicate under-prediction of public support; these are common for both transfer designs. Interestingly, mean predicted support varies less across countries than actual support, indicating that professionals do not fully capture cross-country variation in public attitudes toward subsidy reform. The cross-country variation in public attitudes raises the question as to whether familiarity with a context might be associated with better forecasts, a question to which we will return in later analyses. The remaining analyses examine whether these prediction patterns are systematically related to professionals' own support for the two policy designs and to their personal attributes, including familiarity with the target context.

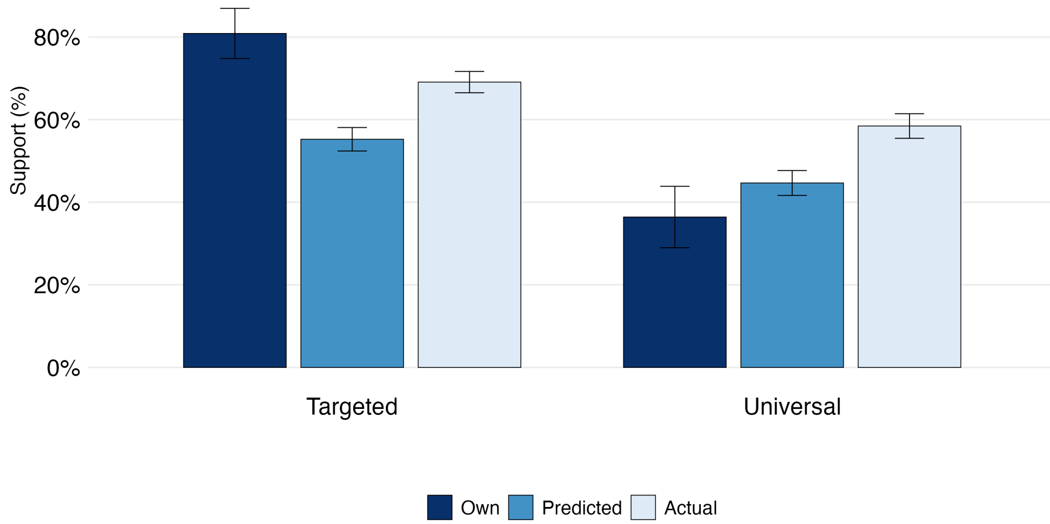

Figure 1: Preferences over Redistributive Programs: Own Support, Predictions, and Actual Public Preferences

Notes: Predicted and actual public support are pooled over forecast observations in the analytic own-support sample, so countries forecast more often receive more weight. Actual public support uses survey-weighted country estimates from the public benchmark data. Error bars show 95% confidence intervals; for actual public support, country-level survey standard errors are combined using forecast-observation country shares.

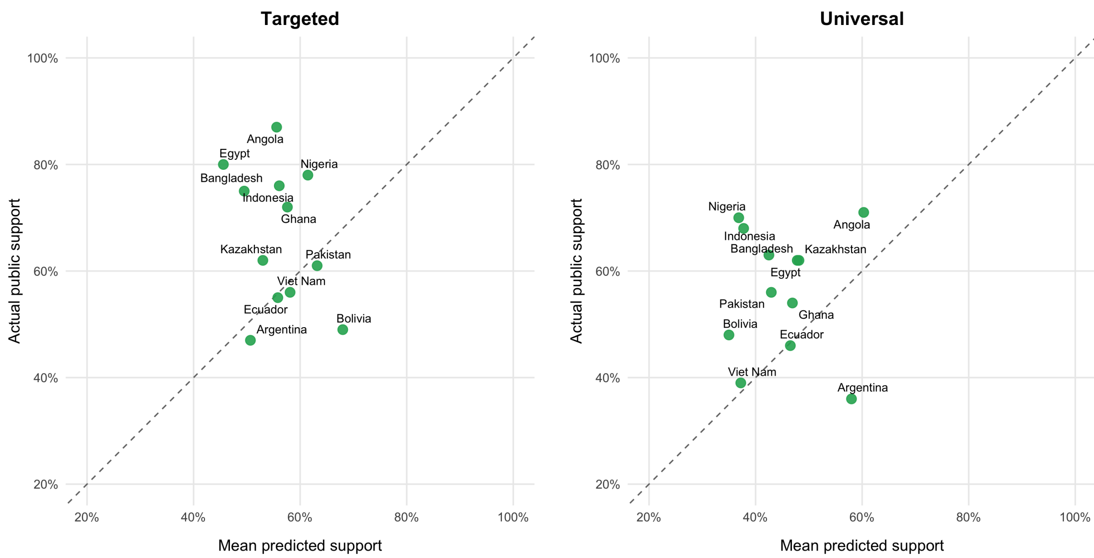

Figure 2: Mean Predicted vs. Actual Public Support, by Country and Policy

Notes: Each point is one of the 12 study countries. The dashed line is the 45-degree line where forecasts match actual support. Points above the dashed line indicate underprediction of public support. Mean predicted support is computed across the 162 World Bank staff respondents in the analytic sample. For targeted transfers, actual public support ranges 47%-87% across countries while mean predicted support ranges 46%-68%; for universal transfers, actual ranges 36%-71% and mean predicted ranges 35%-60%. Mean predicted support varies less across countries than actual public support.

4.2 Correlates of Policy Professionals' Own Preferences

Table 2 presents regression results examining factors associated with policy professionals' redistributive preferences. Having a graduate degree is associated with substantially lower support for universal transfers, but not with lower support for targeted transfers. Childhood family income, which was elicited by asking participants to identify which income decile in their home country their family would have fallen into as they were growing up, is positively associated with support for targeted transfers, while log GDP per capita of the respondent's origin country is positively associated with support for universal transfers and negatively associated with support for targeted transfers. The regressions in Columns (1)-(2) could in principle reflect preferences regarding some other feature of energy subsidies. Column (3) summarizes the within-respondent universal-minus-targeted support gap, focusing on relative support for universal rather than targeted compensation. In that specification, graduate education predicts relatively greater support for targeted over universal transfers, while higher origin-country GDP predicts relatively greater support for universal transfers, and childhood family income is not statistically significant. Appendix Table B2 provides robustness checks with a univariate regression for each variable. Results are slightly less significant but qualitatively similar in magnitude. When graduate education is broken down into different categories - master's degrees versus doctoral degrees - a dose-response relationship between education and support for targeted over universal transfers is suggested, as those with doctoral degrees show an even larger universal-targeted support gap (Appendix Table B3). These associations should be interpreted as descriptive variation within an already selected group of policy professionals. They also show that, despite strong average support for targeting, there is meaningful within-sample variation in support for universal transfers, which we use in the analyses that follow on perceptions of others' preferences.

These patterns also connect the paper to work showing that social position and background shape fairness views (Hvidberg et al., 2023; Roth and Wohlfart, 2018). Even within a selected professional sample, relative support for targeting versus universalism varies systematically with education and origin-country income, suggesting that professionals' weighting of redistributive policy designs is not homogeneous.

Table 2: Determinants of Policy Professionals' Own Support

	Universal Support	Targeted Support	Universal − Targeted
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Has Graduate Degree	−0.25**	0.08	−0.34*
	(0.13)	(0.11)	(0.18)
Childhood Family Income Bucket	−0.00	0.03**	−0.03
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	0.06**	−0.05**	0.11***
	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.04)
Respondent FE	No	No	Absorbed
Observations	150	150	150
R-squared	0.06	0.06	0.10

Notes: Columns (1) and (2) are linear probability models for support for replacing energy subsidies with universal or targeted cash transfers. Column (3) is the within-person difference in support for universal versus targeted transfers, equivalent to a two-policy respondent fixed-effects model with covariates interacted with the universal-policy indicator. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

4.3 Own Support and Predicted Public Support

Table 3 examines whether policy professionals' own support for the two compensation designs is associated with their predictions of public support. The key finding is that respondents who personally support universal transfers predict public support for universal transfers to be 17 percentage points higher than respondents who do not support universal transfers. This relationship is robust to controlling for education, childhood family income, origin-country GDP, regional familiarity, and target-country fixed effects.

Column (3) uses the within respondent-country universal-minus-targeted prediction gap as the outcome, with target-country fixed effects. This specification compares the same respondent's predictions for the same target country across the two policy designs, differencing out respondent-country factors common to both predictions while absorbing country-specific differences in the actual universal-targeted public-support gap. In this specification, own support for universal transfers predicts an approximately 15 percentage point larger predicted universal-minus-targeted public-support gap, while own support for targeted transfers remains small and statistically insignificant. Equivalently, because target-country fixed effects are included, the column can be interpreted as the corresponding signed-error-gap specification. The within respondent-country result therefore reinforces the main pattern: professionals who support universal transfers themselves perceive relatively greater public support for universal transfers.

This pattern is consistent with projection or false-consensus bias: professionals who personally support universal transfers also expect higher public support for universal transfers. The result appears precisely on the margin where professionals are most divided and where professional support differs most from measured public support. By contrast, the coefficient on own support for targeted transfers in Column (2) has the same sign but is not significantly associated with beliefs about public support for targeted transfers, possibly because support for targeted transfers is high and variation in own preferences is more limited.

Table 3: Predicted Public Support

	Predicted Support		Prediction Gap: Universal − Targeted
	Universal	Targeted	Within Respondent-Country
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Own Support: Universal	0.17***	0.04	0.15**
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.06)
Own Support: Targeted	0.05	0.05	0.01
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.07)
Has Graduate Degree	0.03	−0.02	
	(0.07)	(0.07)	
Childhood Family Income Bucket	0.01	−0.01	
	(0.01)	(0.01)	
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	0.02	−0.01	
	(0.01)	(0.01)	
High Region Familiarity	0.07**	−0.02	
	(0.03)	(0.04)	
Target-Country FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respondent-Country Difference	No	No	Yes
Observations	268	269	288
Respondents	150	150	162
R-squared	0.20	0.07	0.10

Notes: Columns (1) and (2) regress predicted public support on own support and controls, with target-country fixed effects. Since actual public support is fixed within country-policy cells, the own-support coefficients in columns (1) and (2) are equivalent to those from signed prediction-error regressions. Column (3) uses the within respondent-country difference between predicted support for universal and targeted transfers, with target-country fixed effects. This differencing removes respondent-country factors common to both predictions, and with target-country fixed effects the coefficients are equivalent to those from the corresponding signed-error-gap regression. High region familiarity equals one when the respondent reports target-region familiarity of 4 or 5 on a 1-5 scale. Standard errors are clustered by respondent. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

4.4 Prediction Errors

Table 4 compares staff predictions to the country-specific public-support benchmarks. This table considers absolute prediction error, where negative coefficients indicate more accurate forecasts.

The absolute-error results build on the prediction results in Table 3 and show the corresponding implications for forecast accuracy. Own support for universal transfers is associated with smaller absolute prediction errors for universal-transfer forecasts. This does not imply that universal-transfer supporters are generally better forecasters; rather, perhaps because most professionals under-predict public support for universal transfers, respondents who personally support universal transfers and predict higher public support are closer to the public benchmark.

High regional familiarity is also associated with lower absolute prediction error for universal-transfer forecasts, though not for targeted-transfer forecasts. We treat the familiarity result as exploratory and suggestive. It appears for high target-region familiarity in the universal-transfer error specification, but not consistently across alternative familiarity measures (Appendix Tables B6-B7).[6] This suggests that context-specific familiarity may improve prediction accuracy in some cases, but the result is policy-specific and should not be interpreted as evidence that local knowledge uniformly corrects misperceptions.

[6]We cannot examine the relationship between being from a given country and prediction error for that country with our sample size: only one participant reported being from one of the twelve countries for which public opinion benchmarks are available.

Table 4: Determinants of Absolute Prediction Error

	Absolute Prediction Error	
	Universal	Targeted
	(1)	(2)
Own Support: Universal	−0.10***	−0.05
	(0.02)	(0.03)
Own Support: Targeted	−0.01	0.01
	(0.03)	(0.04)
Has Graduate Degree	0.00	−0.05
	(0.04)	(0.04)
Childhood Family Income Bucket	−0.00	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.01)
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	−0.01	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.01)
High Region Familiarity	−0.05**	0.01
	(0.02)	(0.03)
Target-Country FE	Yes	Yes
Observations	268	269
Respondents	150	150
R-squared	0.23	0.11

Notes: The dependent variable is absolute prediction error, defined as the absolute difference between predicted public support and actual public support. Positive coefficients indicate larger prediction errors. High region familiarity equals one when the respondent reports target-region familiarity of 4 or 5 on a 1-5 scale. Standard errors are clustered by respondent. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

5 Robustness Checks and Discussion

5.1 Robustness Checks

To assess the sensitivity of the results, we conduct a number of robustness checks provided in the appendix.

First, following the pre-analysis plan, we apply median regression where feasible.[7] The results are provided in Appendix Tables B8 and B9 and are similar to those previously presented in Tables 3-4.

Second, we explore alternative explanatory variables. While in the main regressions we collapse reported education levels to a binary variable indicating whether or not the respondent has a graduate degree, for simplicity, in Appendix Tables B3-B5 we show results decomposing graduate degrees into master's or doctoral degrees. Interestingly, the patterns observed for those with graduate degrees being more likely to support targeted transfers over universal transfers strengthens for those with doctoral degrees as opposed to master's degrees. We also consider two alternative measures of contextual familiarity in Appendix Tables B6 and B7. We do not observe the same relationship for these variables as we did for the variable capturing regional familiarity in Tables 3-4.[8]

Third, following the pre-analysis plan, we restrict the prediction and prediction-error specifications to respondents who did not report prior familiarity with the cash-transfer

[7]Median regression would not make sense for the specifications involving binary dependent variables, as in Table 2.

[8]These variables were binary indicators for being from the same region as the target country to be forecast, or stating they were "Quite Familiar" with or had "Some Work Experience" in the target country. A possible explanation is that these variables were relatively weak proxies for target-country expertise. In particular, merely having been born in a particular region may not be enough to provide in-depth knowledge of preferences of others in countries in the same region, and the question about target-country expertise had been asked as a binary yes/no question capturing whether someone either was quite familiar with or had some work experience in the target country, so we cannot distinguish between the two, and having "some" work experience in a given country may be common at the World Bank and not necessarily imply deep expertise. In contrast, the regional familiarity measure reported in Tables 3-4 required one to rate their expertise of the region as a four or five on a 5-point Likert scale (a pre-specified cut-off threshold), and this level may reflect having worked there for many years and having deeper knowledge of public opinions. However, we do not wish to lean too hard on the results regarding contextual knowledge given the mixed results.

support benchmark. Appendix Tables B10 and B11 report these results. The estimates are qualitatively similar to Tables 3 and 4.

Finally, we conduct some leave-one-country-out robustness checks to mitigate the risk that results are driven by any one country. Table B12 reports the results of these analyses for the predicted support specifications in Table 3, and Table B13 does the same for Table 4. The coefficient on own support for universal transfers is stable across omitted countries.

5.2 Discussion

Professional judgment over redistributive policy design combines at least two distinct elements: preferences over policy instruments and beliefs about what citizens themselves prefer. In our setting, those two elements do not align. Policy professionals strongly favor targeted compensation, while public support is less sharply concentrated on targeting. Professionals partly recognize this difference, but their predictions still understate public support for cash transfer compensation relative to the status quo regressive energy subsidies.

This inaccurate perception of public preferences matters because technical or normative arguments for targeting can easily become entangled with empirical claims about public acceptability. Professionals may have strong reasons to prefer targeted transfers, including concerns about fiscal efficiency, leakage, or directing resources to poorer households. But those reasons are analytically distinct from beliefs about whether citizens support universal or targeted compensation. Our results suggest that direct evidence on public preferences may be needed to help inform policy.

The association between own support and perceived public support should be interpreted cautiously. It is strongest on the universal-transfer margin, where professionals are most divided and where professional and public preferences diverge most. This is consistent with projection or false-consensus mechanisms. However, the same pattern could reflect correlated priors, professional training, ideology, information sets, or beliefs about feasibility. The absence of a comparable significant relationship for targeted transfers also suggests that the pattern is policy-specific rather than a general tendency to project preferences across all redistributive instruments.

High familiarity with the target region is similarly associated with lower prediction error for universal-transfer forecasts, but not for targeted-transfer forecasts. This suggests that contextual exposure may improve some forecasts of public preferences, however, the results caution against a broad claim that local knowledge uniformly corrects misperceptions. Further, robustness checks considering alternative forms of local knowledge do not show this effect (Appendix Tables B6 and B7).

This paper does not argue that public preferences should mechanically determine redistributive policy. Policy design also requires technical evidence, fiscal analysis, and administrative judgment, and there are normative questions around policies with redistributive impacts. But when reforms depend on public acceptance, compliance, or political sustainability, beliefs about public preferences become part of the policy problem itself. In such settings, systematically measuring public preferences can improve policy design by clarifying what citizens support, where professional expectations are accurate, and where those expectations may partly reflect professionals' own priors.

Several limitations should be noted. First, our sample is limited to World Bank staff surveyed at headquarters and may not generalize to policy professionals in other organizations, government agencies, or country offices. Second, the survey's focus - energy subsidy reform in exchange for cash transfers - is specific, and results may differ for other redistributive policies. Third, staff's own preferences were elicited generally rather than for each target country, so we interpret them as respondent-level preferences over redistributive policy designs rather than country-specific preferences. Fourth, the public benchmarks come from online surveys weighted to match population characteristics; they provide large and standardized measures of public support, but may not fully capture preferences among populations with limited internet access. Finally, while the relationship we document between preferences and predictions is suggestive of projection bias or a false-consensus effect, we cannot identify the causal effect of own preferences on predictions.

6 Conclusion

Policy professionals help design redistributive programs, yet little is known about how their own preferences compare with public preferences or how accurately they perceive what citizens prefer. This paper provides some of the first evidence on policy professionals' preferences for standard redistributive policy tools and their ability to predict public preferences regarding the same.

We find that World Bank staff hold preferences that differ substantially from the general public, favoring targeted over universal transfers to a much greater degree. When predicting public preferences, professionals partially adjust away from their own views. However, their own support for universal transfers is associated with higher perceived public support for universality, consistent with projection bias or a false-consensus effect. We also find suggestive evidence that familiarity with specific contexts is associated with lower prediction error, though not uniformly across transfer types and alternative measures of familiarity.

These findings contribute to our understanding of perceptions about policies with strong distributional impacts and perceptions of others' preferences. Public preferences should not mechanically determine policy choices, but in politically salient reforms they are an important input into feasibility and implementation. Measuring those preferences directly can help clarify where professional judgments reflect public acceptability and where they reflect professionals' own prior beliefs.

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the manuscript preparation process:

During the preparation of this work, the authors used Codex 5.5 and Claude Opus 4.7 to prepare clean replication files and suggest edits to an existing draft for clarity. The authors reviewed and edited the output as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the published article.

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A Deviations from the Pre-Analysis Plan

The pre-analysis plan specified two broad families of outcomes: predictions of preferred income distributions, based on the International Social Survey Programme (ISSP) -style distributional questions, and predictions of public support for energy-subsidy reform paired with universal or targeted cash transfers. The final analysis focuses on the cash-transfer outcomes. We do not analyze the ISSP-style outcomes because responses to those questions suggested that respondents did not consistently understand the task, making the resulting measures difficult to interpret. This is the main substantive deviation from the pre-analysis plan. This experience also illustrates a methodological limitation of abstract distributional elicitation in this setting: even in a highly educated professional sample, the ISSP-style distributional questions did not yield responses that were interpretable enough for the main analysis.

Several other changes reflect either data availability or the structure of the realized survey data. The pre-analysis plan listed age as a respondent attribute, but age was not collected, so it is not included in the analysis. The plan also anticipated using whether the respondent was from the same country or region as the forecast target and target-country familiarity in addition to regional familiarity. In the realized data, only one respondent-target-country observation involved a respondent from the same country as the country being forecast, so same-country status is not used as a covariate. The main specifications instead use high familiarity with the target region, defined as a 4 or 5 on the 1-5 regional familiarity scale, while appendix robustness checks consider same-origin-region status and target-country familiarity, both collected as binary variables. Education is summarized in the main text with a graduate-degree indicator, with appendix robustness checks separating master's and doctoral degrees. Finally, we added log GDP per capita to help interpret the childhood family income bin question, though results without this variable are available upon request.

The pre-analysis plan described forecast accuracy using RMSE-style measures. For the cash-transfer forecasts, the final analysis uses absolute prediction error as the main accuracy outcome, measured as the absolute difference between predicted and actual public support for a given country-policy pair. This keeps the unit of analysis at the forecast level and makes coefficients interpretable in percentage-point terms. The paper also reports predicted public support itself, since this directly shows whether respondents' own preferences are associated with beliefs about public preferences. For predicted public support, we also include within respondent-country gap specifications comparing universal and targeted transfers for the same respondent and target country, with target-country fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered by respondent, as specified in the pre-analysis plan, and median-regression robustness checks are reported in the appendix.

B Appendix Tables

Table B1: Cross-Country Comparison of Utility Spending and Electricity Subsidy Incidence

Country	Measure	Top	Bottom	Ratio	Source
Angola	Utilities Spending	4629 Kz/mth	106 Kz/mth	43.7x	Quadros de Resultados IDREA 2018-2019
Argentina	Electricity Subsidy	44,515 ARS/mth	33,472 ARS/mth	1.3x	La Encuesta Nacional de Gastos de los Hogares (ENGHo) 2017-2018
Bangladesh	Electricity Subsidy Share	42%	6%	7.0x	World Bank Report 76441-BD (2013)
Bolivia	Electricity & Fuel Spending	7,348 Bs/mth	1,189 Bs/mth	6.2x	Encuesta de Presupuestos Familiares 2015-2016
Ecuador	-	-	-	-	-
Egypt	Electricity Subsidy Share	39%	10%	3.9x	World Bank, *Impact of Fiscal Policy on Inequality and Poverty in the Arab Republic of Egypt* (2019)
Ghana	Electricity & Fuel Spending	381 GH/mth	72 GH/mth	5.3x	Ghana Living Standard Survey (GLSS 7) 2017
Indonesia	Electricity Spending	227,900 IDR/mth	36,700 IDR/mth	6.2x	AFD Inequality Diagnostic Report (2023)
Kazakhstan	-	-	-	-	-
Nigeria	Electricity Subsidy Share	27.10%	14%	1.9x	Soile & Mu (2015)
Pakistan	Electricity Subsidy Share	28%	4.90%	5.7x	World Bank, *Pakistan Federal Public Expenditure Review* 2023
Vietnam	Utilities Spending	720,400 VND/mth	60,200 VND/mth	12.0x	Viet Nam Household Living Standards Survey 2022

Notes: This table reports the cross-country subsidy-incidence and utility-spending comparisons underlying the claim that energy subsidies are highly regressive in the countries studied. "Top" and "Bottom" refer to the highest- and lowest-income groups reported in each source. "mth" denotes monthly values. No comparable data was identified for Kazakhstan or Ecuador.

Table B2: Univariate Marginal Effects of Respondent Covariates on Each Own-Support Outcome

	Universal	Targeted	Universal − Targeted
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Has Graduate Degree			
(N = 159)	−0.31**	0.12	−0.43**
	(0.12)	(0.12)	(0.19)
Childhood Family Income Bucket			
(N = 153)	−0.01	0.03**	−0.04
	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.03)
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)			
(N = 156)	0.06*	−0.04	0.09**
	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.04)

Notes: Each cell reports the coefficient from a univariate linear regression of the column outcome on the row covariate. Columns (1) and (2) regress the respondent's binary support for universal or targeted cash transfers on a single covariate; column (3) uses the within-person difference (universal minus targeted) as the outcome. Sample size varies by row because of non-missing patterns: 159 respondents for graduate degree, 153 respondents for childhood family income, 156 respondents for log GDP per capita. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B3: Education Decomposition Robustness for Policy Professionals' Own Support

	Universal Support	Targeted Support	Universal − Targeted
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Master's Degree	−0.22*	0.08	−0.30*
	(0.13)	(0.11)	(0.18)
Doctoral Degree	−0.39***	0.09	−0.48**
	(0.14)	(0.13)	(0.20)
Childhood Family Income Bucket	0.00	0.03**	−0.03
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	0.07**	−0.05**	0.12***
	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.04)
Respondent FE	No	No	Absorbed
Observations	150	150	150
R-squared	0.08	0.06	0.11

Notes: Columns (1) and (2) are linear probability models for support for replacing energy subsidies with universal or targeted cash transfers. Column (3) is the within-person difference in support for universal versus targeted transfers. Bachelor's degree or less is the omitted education category. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B4: Education Decomposition Robustness for Predicted Public Support

	Predicted Support		Prediction Gap: Universal − Targeted
	Universal	Targeted	Within Respondent-Country
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Own Support: Universal	0.18***	0.04	0.15**
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.06)
Own Support: Targeted	0.05	0.05	0.01
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.07)
Master's Degree	0.02	−0.02	
	(0.07)	(0.07)	
Doctoral Degree	0.09	−0.02	
	(0.08)	(0.08)	
Childhood Family Income Bucket	0.01	−0.01	
	(0.01)	(0.01)	
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	0.02	−0.01	
	(0.01)	(0.01)	
High Region Familiarity	0.07**	−0.02	
	(0.03)	(0.04)	
Target-Country FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respondent-Country Difference	No	No	Yes
Observations	268	269	288
Respondents	150	150	162
R-squared	0.21	0.07	0.10

Notes: These specifications repeat Table 3, replacing the graduate-degree indicator with indicators for master's and doctoral degrees. Column (3) uses the within respondent-country universal-minus-targeted prediction gap and includes target-country fixed effects, making the own-support coefficients equivalent to those from the corresponding signed-error-gap regression. Bachelor's degree or less is the omitted education category. Standard errors are clustered by respondent. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B5: Education Decomposition Robustness for Absolute Prediction Error

	Absolute Prediction Error	
	Universal	Targeted
	(1)	(2)
Own Support: Universal	−0.10***	−0.05
	(0.02)	(0.03)
Own Support: Targeted	−0.01	0.01
	(0.03)	(0.04)
Master's Degree	−0.00	−0.06
	(0.04)	(0.04)
Doctoral Degree	0.01	−0.03
	(0.05)	(0.05)
Childhood Family Income Bucket	−0.01	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.01)
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	−0.01	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.01)
High Region Familiarity	−0.05**	0.01
	(0.02)	(0.03)
Target-Country FE	Yes	Yes
Observations	268	269
Respondents	150	150
R-squared	0.23	0.11

Notes: These specifications repeat Table 4, replacing the graduate-degree indicator with indicators for master's and doctoral degrees. Bachelor's degree or less is the omitted education category. Standard errors are clustered by respondent. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B6: Alternative Familiarity Measures for Predicted Public Support

	Predicted Support		Prediction Gap: Universal − Targeted
	Universal	Targeted	Within Respondent-Country
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Own Support: Universal	0.17***	0.04	0.15**
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.06)
Own Support: Targeted	0.04	0.05	0.01
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.07)
Has Graduate Degree	0.03	−0.02	
	(0.07)	(0.07)	
Childhood Family Income Bucket	0.01	−0.01	
	(0.01)	(0.01)	
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	0.02	−0.01	
	(0.01)	(0.01)	
Same Origin Region	0.05	0.01	
	(0.04)	(0.04)	
Target Country Familiarity	0.01	−0.05	
	(0.04)	(0.04)	
Target-Country FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respondent-Country Difference	No	No	Yes
Observations	268	269	288
Respondents	150	150	162
R-squared	0.19	0.08	0.10

Notes: These specifications repeat Table 3, replacing high target-region familiarity with same-origin-region and target-country familiarity indicators. Column (3) uses the within respondent-country universal-minus-targeted prediction gap and includes target-country fixed effects, making the own-support coefficients equivalent to those from the corresponding signed-error-gap regression. Standard errors are clustered by respondent. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B7: Alternative Familiarity Measures for Absolute Prediction Error

	Absolute Prediction Error	
	Universal	Targeted
	(1)	(2)
Own Support: Universal	−0.10***	−0.05*
	(0.02)	(0.03)
Own Support: Targeted	−0.02	0.00
	(0.03)	(0.04)
Has Graduate Degree	−0.00	−0.05
	(0.04)	(0.04)
Childhood Family Income Bucket	−0.00	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.01)
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	−0.01	0.01
	(0.01)	(0.01)
Same Origin Region	0.00	0.03
	(0.02)	(0.02)
Target Country Familiarity	−0.02	−0.01
	(0.02)	(0.03)
Target-Country FE	Yes	Yes
Observations	268	269
Respondents	150	150
R-squared	0.21	0.11

Notes: These specifications repeat Table 4, replacing high target-region familiarity with same-origin-region and target-country familiarity indicators. Standard errors are clustered by respondent. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B8: Median Regression Robustness for Predicted Public Support

	Predicted Support		Prediction Gap: Universal − Targeted
	Universal	Targeted	Within Respondent-Country
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Own Support: Universal	0.23***	0.01	0.20***
	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.07)
Own Support: Targeted	0.04	0.02	-0.00
	(0.06)	(0.09)	(0.08)
Has Graduate Degree	0.04	−0.07	
	(0.13)	(0.12)	
Childhood Family Income Bucket	0.01	−0.01	
	(0.01)	(0.02)	
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	0.02	−0.00	
	(0.02)	(0.02)	
High Region Familiarity	0.05	−0.05	
	(0.05)	(0.07)	
Target-Country FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respondent-Country Difference	No	No	Yes
Observations	268	269	288
Respondents	150	150	162

Notes: These specifications repeat Table 3 using median regression. Columns (1) and (2) include target-country fixed effects; column (3) uses the within respondent-country universal-minus-targeted prediction gap and also includes target-country fixed effects, making the own-support coefficients equivalent to those from the corresponding signed-error-gap regression. Standard errors are clustered by respondent using the cluster bootstrap implemented in `quantreg`, with 1,000 replications. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B9: Median Regression Robustness for Absolute Prediction Error

	Absolute Prediction Error	
	Universal	Targeted
	(1)	(2)
Own Support: Universal	−0.12***	−0.04
	(0.03)	(0.04)
Own Support: Targeted	−0.02	0.03
	(0.04)	(0.05)
Has Graduate Degree	−0.04	−0.07
	(0.05)	(0.07)
Childhood Family Income Bucket	−0.00	0.01
	(0.01)	(0.01)
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	−0.01	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.01)
High Region Familiarity	−0.05	0.03
	(0.03)	(0.04)
Target-Country FE	Yes	Yes
Observations	268	269
Respondents	150	150

Notes: These specifications repeat Table 4 using median regression. Standard errors are clustered by respondent using the cluster bootstrap implemented in `quantreg`, with 1,000 replications. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B10: Prior-Exposure Robustness for Predicted Public Support

	Predicted Support		Prediction Gap: Universal − Targeted
	Universal	Targeted	Within Respondent-Country
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Own Support: Universal	0.18***	0.08	0.14*
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.07)
Own Support: Targeted	0.03	0.01	0.04
	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.08)
Has Graduate Degree	0.02	−0.06	
	(0.07)	(0.07)	
Childhood Family Income Bucket	0.01	−0.01	
	(0.01)	(0.01)	
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	−0.00	−0.02	
	(0.02)	(0.02)	
High Region Familiarity	0.11**	−0.01	
	(0.04)	(0.05)	
Target-Country FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respondent-Country Difference	No	No	Yes
Observations	189	190	204
Respondents	104	104	113
R-squared	0.20	0.09	0.09

Notes: These specifications repeat Table 3, restricting to respondents who did not report prior familiarity with the cash-transfer support benchmark. Column (3) uses the within respondent-country universal-minus-targeted prediction gap and includes target-country fixed effects, making the own-support coefficients equivalent to those from the corresponding signed-error-gap regression. Standard errors are clustered by respondent. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B11: Prior-Exposure Robustness for Absolute Prediction Error

	Absolute Prediction Error	
	Universal	Targeted
	(1)	(2)
Own Support: Universal	−0.10***	−0.04
	(0.03)	(0.04)
Own Support: Targeted	−0.01	0.06
	(0.04)	(0.04)
Has Graduate Degree	0.00	−0.01
	(0.05)	(0.04)
Childhood Family Income Bucket	−0.00	0.01
	(0.01)	(0.01)
Log GDP per Capita (Origin Country)	0.00	0.01
	(0.01)	(0.01)
High Region Familiarity	−0.06*	0.01
	(0.03)	(0.03)
Target-Country FE	Yes	Yes
Observations	189	190
Respondents	104	104
R-squared	0.20	0.13

Notes: These specifications repeat Table 4, restricting to respondents who did not report prior familiarity with the cash-transfer support benchmark. Standard errors are clustered by respondent. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B12: Leave-One-Country-Out Robustness for Predicted Public Support

Omitted Country	Predicted Support: Universal Own Universal Support	Predicted Support: Targeted Own Targeted Support	Prediction Gap: Universal − Targeted: Within Respondent-Country Own Universal Support
None (full sample)	0.17***	0.05	0.15**
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Angola	0.18***	0.04	0.16***
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Argentina	0.17***	0.05	0.15**
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Bangladesh	0.17***	0.04	0.15**
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Bolivia	0.18***	0.05	0.15**
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Ecuador	0.16***	0.03	0.16***
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Egypt	0.17***	0.07	0.14**
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Ghana	0.18***	0.05	0.14**
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Indonesia	0.16***	0.05	0.16***
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Kazakhstan	0.19***	0.04	0.18***
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Nigeria	0.17***	0.07	0.14**
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Pakistan	0.17***	0.06	0.15**
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)
Vietnam	0.17***	0.06	0.14**
	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.06)

Notes: Each row re-estimates the three predicted-support specifications in Table 3 after omitting the named target country. Cells report the coefficient listed in the column header, with clustered standard errors in parentheses. The first two columns include the same controls as Table 3 and target-country fixed effects. The within respondent-country column uses the universal-minus-targeted prediction gap as the outcome and includes target-country fixed effects; with these fixed effects, its coefficients are equivalent to those from the corresponding signed-error-gap regression. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B13: Leave-One-Country-Out Robustness for Prediction-Error Results

Omitted Country	Absolute Prediction Error	
	Universal Error	Targeted Error
	Own Universal Support	Own Targeted Support
None (full sample)	−0.10*** (0.02)	0.01 (0.04)
Angola	−0.11*** (0.02)	0.02 (0.03)
Argentina	−0.10*** (0.02)	0.01 (0.04)
Bangladesh	−0.09*** (0.03)	0.02 (0.04)
Bolivia	−0.10*** (0.02)	0.01 (0.04)
Ecuador	−0.12*** (0.03)	0.02 (0.04)
Egypt	−0.10*** (0.03)	−0.00 (0.04)
Ghana	−0.10*** (0.02)	0.00 (0.04)
Indonesia	−0.08*** (0.03)	0.01 (0.04)
Kazakhstan	−0.09*** (0.02)	−0.00 (0.04)
Nigeria	−0.08*** (0.02)	−0.01 (0.04)
Pakistan	−0.10*** (0.03)	0.01 (0.04)
Vietnam	−0.10*** (0.03)	0.00 (0.04)

Notes: Each row re-estimates the two prediction-error specifications in Table 4 after omitting the named target country. Cells report the coefficient listed in the column header, with clustered standard errors in parentheses. Both columns include the same controls as Table 4 and target-country fixed effects. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

C Appendix Figures

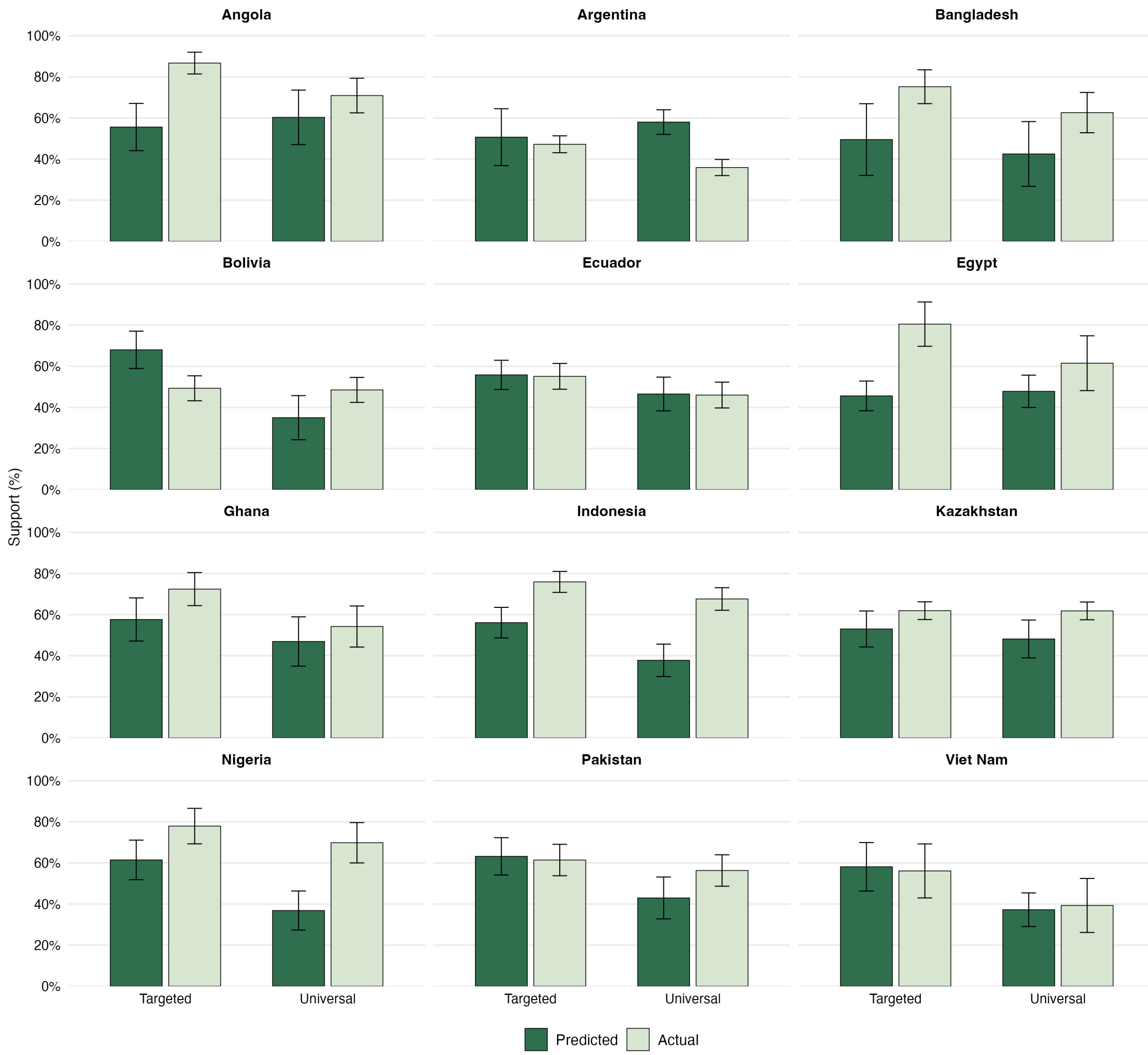

Figure C1: Predicted and Actual Public Support, by Target Country

Notes: Bars show predicted and actual public support for targeted and universal cash transfers in each target country. Forecasts are restricted to the 162-respondent analytic sample used in the predicted support regressions. Error bars show 95% confidence intervals for mean predicted support. Actual public support is shown as a benchmark point estimate from the public-opinion data.

Respondents in Pakistan were asked whether they would prefer that the government maintain electricity and fuel subsidies at current levels or reduce the subsidies and use the resources previously spent on the subsidies to implement one of the programs below. Reducing the subsidies would lead to electricity and fuel prices increasing by 10%.

What share of respondents do you think answered that they strongly supported or somewhat supported reducing the subsidies and using the funds for each of the following kinds of cash transfer programs?

We provide the share that strongly supported or somewhat supported reducing the subsidies in exchange for implementing several other programs in Pakistan, below, for guidance.

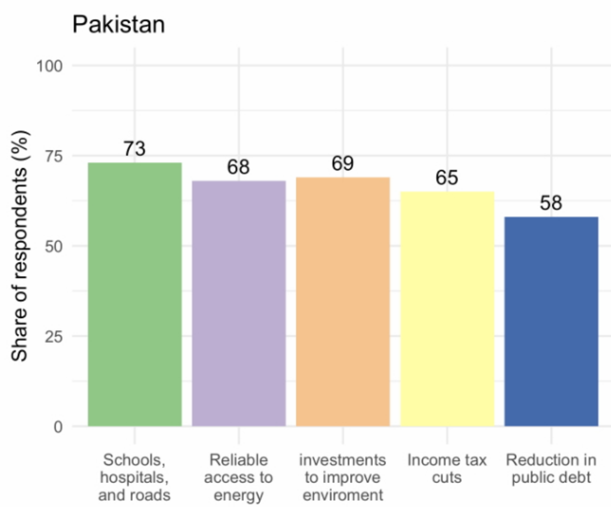

Figure C2: Survey Instrument: Sample Country Context for Predictions

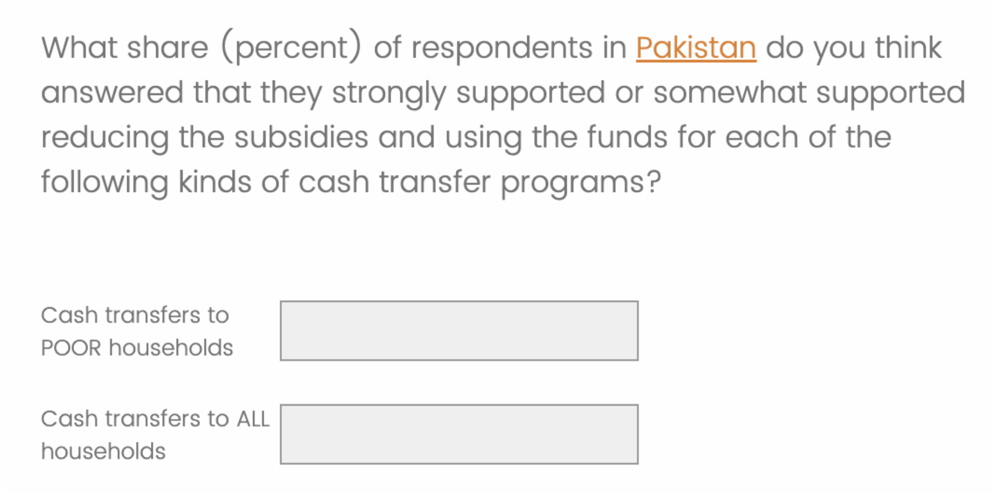

Figure C3: Survey Instrument: Prediction Question

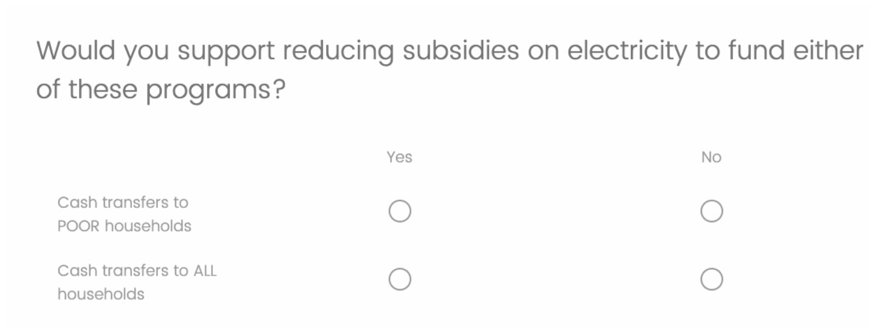

Figure C4: Policy Professionals' Own Preferences for Redistributive Policy Designs